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Impact of hip-hop

Hip-hop has become one of the most influential and widely streamed music genres in the world, shaping not only the music scene, but the way people speak, dress, and express themselves. Despite its popularity, hip-hop has always been faced with a lot of criticism for its recurring themes of violence, misogyny, and materialism, leading many to question its overall impact on society. Some critics argue that such themes reinforce negative stereotypes and promote and contribute to unruly behaviors, particularly within marginalized communities. However, this view on hip-hop often overlooks the historical and social context in which hip-hop was created and continues to evolve in. Originating in the 1970s from communities affected by high poverty rates, racism, and overall neglect, hip-hop has always been more than just entertainment. It has served as a platform of expression for artists whose voices are often ignored and provides them a way to reflect their living experiences and raise awareness for injustice. Although hip-hop is often criticized for its aggressive themes, it serves as a powerful platform for artists to protest systemic inequality and challenge oppressive social conditions.

Hip-hop originated as a direct response to inequality, so, from the very beginning, it's clear that resistance and expression were core ideas surrounding the genre. Rather than being just another form of entertainment, hip-hop developed in marginalized communities as a form of expression, as other traditional forms weren't accessible. It gave people a way to speak about their experiences, push back against inequality, and come together as a group to "survive." As

professor Nick De Genova explains, “rap music brings together a tangle of some of the most complex social, cultural, and political issues in contemporary American society,” showing that hip-hop is made of real issues that people faced rather than just for entertainment. He explains that the communities where hip-hop emerged were in “spiraling misery” and “generalized erosion” due to the “heightened inequalities in the urban division of labor... reductions in federal funding for social services... and the dwindling stock of affordable housing.” These unfortunate conditions can obviously create an environment of depression, frustration, and anger, which is exactly what led to hip-hop. Fittingly, De Genova emphasizes that these conditions are “certainly crucial to an understanding of the origins of hip-hop,” which shows that hip-hop did not *cause* any social issues in the late 1900s, but rather stemmed from them (De Genova). The former is a common misconception that critics often fail to acknowledge.

Similarly, Lakeyta Bonnette-Bailey agrees that hip-hop has always been a form of protest music, giving artists a platform to respond to racism and inequality. She says, “When hip-hop rose in the 1970s, its sheer existence was a form of protest... its rhythms to its art and lyrics were direct counterpositions to mainstream ideals.” This shows why hip-hop was able to have the impact it did: It stuck out. One might ask, “why would a whole new genre have to be invented to protest?” If hip-hop’s political messages were integrated into 70s pop music, it wouldn’t have had the same impact because it wouldn’t have been noticed. It wasn’t just the lyrics that explicitly called out society, it was the style of the music that stuck out from traditional music. Its beats, vocals, and other elements that made it a whole new unique genre challenged the music scene and subsequently challenged society. She reinforces the idea that hip-hop is a “political outlet” that lets artists actively critique the world. She further explains that rapping became “the most prominent element of the culture” because “rap’s use of words not

only expressed discontent poetically but also related to audiences and demonstrated group consciousness or cognitive liberation.” In other words, hip-hop did more than just convey one individual artist’s discontent. It raised awareness not only for people outside of marginalized communities, but also inside them. It called out to them and asked them to evaluate their lives and question their conditions. However, this idea of “group consciousness” wasn’t new. In the past, music such as church hymns had been a big part of the Black community as a way to resist oppression and “express feelings of anger, sadness, and joy.” Additionally, during slavery, “spiritual songs were one of their few means of communicating among themselves and protesting,” showing how music has always been a tool for resistance (Bonnette Bailey). By continuing the tradition of resistance, hip-hop became more than entertainment. It connected people through shared experience.

Hip-hop goes beyond just reflecting social conditions or expressing frustration. It’s a political force that is leveraged by artists to organize and shape movements. As researcher Thami F. Fadil explains, “historically, with the release of songs in the US such as ‘Yankee Doodle,’ protest songs have served as an effective means of communicating with many people in a way that they can understand and relate to.” Fadil also notes that songs like “Strange Fruit” from 1939, which protested the lynching of African Americans, helped raise awareness, proving that music is a successful platform of protest. Fadil argues that hip-hop can be “both the mirror and the engine of a social movement,” meaning it not only *reflects* inequality, but also drives change.

This is especially evident in Public Enemy’s album *It Takes a Nation of Millions to Hold Us* (1988). The music group, “made up mostly of college-educated, activist-minded young men,” rejected traditional music of the 80s and used a loud, chaotic backbeat to reflect the chaos that Black people and communities faced in that time period. The strongest example on this album is

“Bring the Noise.” The loud opening to the album is a message, saying that Black artists have the right to influence American culture and politics too, declaring, “Too black, too strong.” The alarms and other random loud noises in the background display resistance through sound, reflecting the dissonant sounds of protest and fighting. From the same album, “Don’t Believe the Hype” is another “black power song,” and it was considered “very vital” to the movement (Fadil).

Public Enemy’s influence and their style of hip hop can be traced to one of my favorite albums, Joey Bada\$\$’s *1999* (2012). While the two albums are placed in very different time periods, *1999* carries forward the tradition of protesting racial inequality. On the track “Survival Tactics,” Joey Badass addresses contemporary issues of police violence, corrupt politicians, and overall racial inequality, reflecting Public Enemy’s call for such awareness. “Survival Tactics” is a very loud, confrontational, and empowering track (like “Bring the Noise”) which stands out from the rest of the songs on the album. Half-way through the track, a background voice shouts “f*ck the police...f*ck every corrupt politician on Wall-Street...P.E., Public Enemy, assassinate us... f*ck government,” among other aggressive lines, showing how seriously the song takes its message. Joey Badass is saying that African Americans in the US are still treated like the “public enemy,” targeted by the government and police, reflecting contemporary issues of police violence that have unfortunately continued into the present. Joey Badass is showing that hip-hop is a powerful, explicitly political platform that combats inequality and oppression. By mentioning Public Enemy in the song a few times, Joey is aligning himself with their mission: force people to face contemporary racism that is so often overlooked and normalized. The connection between the two albums and artists shows the legacy of hip-hop and especially the foundations that Public Enemy established for future black artists.

Furthermore, Beyonce and Kendrick Lamar are another couple great examples of using their music as a platform to comment on contemporary social issues. Beyonce's album *Lemonade* and Kendrick Lamar's album *To Pimp a Butterfly* confront systemic issues like police brutality and racism, helping push the political topics into mainstream media and serving as inspiration for other artists to be more vocal in their music. Their hits "Formation" (Beyonce) and "Alright" (Lamar) even became "anthems" of the Black Lives Matter movement (Fadil). In Kendrick's "Alright," the defiant message "we gon' be alright" is repeated many times throughout the song as a message of resilience. The song has been chanted at many protests, proving that hip-hop can get past the musical barrier and actually be effective. While hip-hop is a powerful and influential form of expression, some argue that it can promote harmful behavior.

De Genova, although supporting hip-hop, recognizes some of the limitations of hip-hop's social influence, especially how it can be misinterpreted. He says that "exaggerated media coverage of violent incidents at rap shows refortifies hegemonic constructions of black criminality," showing black audiences influenced by rap as dangerous. The media approaches these situations with bias, exaggerating situations and constructing narratives that associate hip-hop with violence instead of just reporting on the situation. De Genova also notes that reformation movements, even strictly within the hip-hop community like "Stop the Violence," sometimes "uncritically adopted this kind of media sensationalism in their efforts to confront so-called black-on-black crime" (De Genova). This shows how far the biased narratives go to make hip-hop seem bad. Even those trying to challenge and "stop" violence end up just reinforcing the narratives due to bias. Similar to the misconception that hip-hop "causes" social issues within marginalized communities, hip-hop does not encourage negative behavior. It's the exaggerated portrayal of hip-hop that influences public perception.

Professor Charis Kubrin argues that rap lyrics depict violence because they're rooted in the realities of disadvantaged environments. She explains that "in extremely disadvantaged neighborhoods, residents learn the value of having a 'name,' or a reputation for being violent, as a means of survival," suggesting that violent lyrics reflect living experiences rather than being for looks. In her analysis of nearly 2000 of the most popular rap songs from the 1990s, she found that themes like "respect," "violence," and "retaliation" were the most popular in the lyrics. She says that "rap lyrics are discursive actions that help construct an interpretive environment where violence is appropriate and acceptable," and according to her findings, 68% of the 2000 songs included a theme of respect, and 65% included a theme of violence (Kubrin). From Kubrin's perspective, hip-hop risks normalizing the harsh realities by shaping how listeners interpret the meaning of simple concepts like respect.

Similarly, critic John McWhorter expresses similar concerns by arguing that rap can harmfully influence behavior. In an article of City Journal, he recalls a time where he observed a group of eight middle-school-aged boys. He described them as "loud and unruly," and said that their "hard-edged rap, preaching bone-deep dislike of authority, provided them with a continuing soundtrack to their antisocial behavior." McWhorter goes as far as to say that those who consider hip-hop to be some sort of political force "couldn't be more wrong" and that "rap retards black success" (McWhorter). McWhorter's interpretation of hip-hop is very similar to Kubrin's, where hip-hop is not a reflection of bad environments, but a cause of such situations.

Hip-hop is often criticized for its frequent references to violence and crime, but these themes should not be taken at face value. They're not just themes meant to intimidate or even glorify the use of violence. They're reflections of real social conditions that artists live through. A larger study conducted by Minsu Park and his colleagues challenges Kubrin and McWhorter's

claim that hip-hop promotes violence. Their research analyzed over 26,000 rap songs from 1990 to 2015 and found that lyrical themes like violence, misogyny, and materialism correlated very closely with social and economic conditions of the time. Over time, the vulgar themes in rap became more frequent and intense, however, Park's study found that rather than increasing linearly or randomly over time, the themes fluctuated very closely alongside things like poverty and crime rates, proving that hip-hop responds to and reflects social conditions rather than causing them. Violence in hip-hop is evidence of inequality, not proof of harm. Furthermore, Park highlighted a limitation of arguments like Kubrin's, saying that "the focus on Billboard hits or specific sub-genres like Gangsta rap excludes a substantial body of work from independent or underground artists, known for their rich and less commercialized self-expression and widespread influence." By focusing primarily on only the most popular songs, critics risk misinterpreting the genre as a whole. Additionally, Park notes that "major record labels have increasingly pressured artists to emphasize violence, misogyny, and materialism, viewing these themes as 'bankable.'" All together, the evidence found by Park disproves the idea that hip-hop independently produces harmful or unruly behavior, showing instead that it reflects and is shaped by broader issues.

Hip-hop is more than just entertainment. It's a platform of resistance and expression. Originating from marginalized communities, hip-hop has always had a deeper meaning, reflecting social conditions to raise awareness and call for help. Recurring themes of violence are not evidence of harm, but rather responses to systemic issues. Hip-hop also goes beyond just reflection, it gives artists a voice to raise awareness, promote change, and challenge the very injustice that causes marginalization. However, the misinterpretation of hip-hop can lead society

to view it in a rather negative, or stereotypical way. Yet, whenever it's approached with an open and correct mindset, it's clear that hip-hop is not the problem, but a powerful response to it.

Writer's Memo

In this essay, the greatest difficulty I faced was finding two additional sources. I didn't want to just choose another source that was similar to the four I had originally, so the search was much harder. Honestly, I didn't really know what I was searching for. I didn't know what direction to take, but I ended up stumbling upon Park's research, and I knew immediately that it would be a perfect source because it disproved Kubrin and McWhorter's counterarguments. I think I framed the counter + rebuttal very well and that there are no gaps in any of the logic. After finding the sources, I pulled my favorite quotes from them and started making an outline. I already knew what I wanted to argue because of the Synthesis essay, and organizing my ideas into clear bodies was not too difficult. Throughout writing this essay, as well as the Synthesis and Exploratory essays, I strengthened my abilities to use direct quotes from sources as evidence. I think I did a really good job at arguing my point.

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